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Joe Muranyi

Clarinetist Joe Muranyi was born in Martin's Ferry, Ohio on January 14, 1928. He has worked as a record producer for major labels and played alongside Roy Eldridge, Jimmy McPartland and Max Kaminsky. Joe was a member of the Louis Armstrong All-Stars from 1967-1971.

Joe was interviewed in New York City on January 11, 2007 by Monk Rowe, director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. Tim Hicks and Vince Giordano participated briefly in the interview.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're in Manhattan at the International Association of Jazz Educators conference. I'm pleased to have Joe Muranyi with me this afternoon. Did I pronounce your name good?

JM: Yeah that's pretty good.

MR: In Hungary they do it different, is that right?

JM: In Hungary, I wouldn't say it's a common name but everybody pronounces it correctly: mu-ray-nee is how they say it.

MR: Well in reading about you it seems like an interesting trip from balalaika orchestras to Lenny Tristano to Louis Armstrong to what you're doing now.

JM: Well that balalaika is one of those things, you know, you say something that's off-beat or not in the normal events in the course of normal events, and that triggers up. Yeah. When I was going to college, you know, I went to Columbia and Manhattan School of Music, I sort of gigged around. I played with, I actually played with an old time Italian band, you know a street band sort of. We didn't play in the street, but it was in Springfield, Mass. in some Catholic church basement. And that was an experience you know. You had no music, these old guys, it's like the equivalent New Orleans or something. And they played standard classical repertoire and they had flute, clarinet, oboe, you know, it was like, the balalaikas were like the violins and the violas and all that stuff. And they played classical stuff and Glinka and things like that from the Russian days. And they also played Russian folk songs (sings) which was ethnic again. It was kind of fun.

MR: Well it's a great mix for your ears to be doing all that kind of stuff, right?

JM: Oh yeah. I love so-called ethnic music you know. I used to have quite a collection of klezmer stuff, which I like very much, and there again, the earlier the better. In the twenty-something it was just wonderful. The new klezmer bands well they're fun and stuff but they don't have the level of anything like the old timers did.

MR: Was music a big part of your household when you were young?

JM: Yeah I think so. My parents were musical. They sang and — they didn't play any instruments, nor in my mother's family there were a lot of brothers and sisters, they didn't play anything. But I recently learned that my grandfather, my father's father, played violin and guitar which was a surprise to me. I barely remember him. But they were always musical, and I always thought that, you know, Hungarians had a natural affinity for music like Italians, Irish, something like that. And in recent years, the past 20 years or so, I've gone there a lot and I find that I was basing my opinion of Hungarians on my parents and my family. Because not all black people have rhythm, no. It's very similar. You know. So but music was a very important part and you know I'm getting to the age where I've had thoughts and funny thoughts and I cheer up easily. And I'm an emotional being. Of course we all are. But the other night, there was something about "Pennies From Heaven." The song came up. And I had this recall of, I have two grandkids, George and Charles. And George is seven and Charles is five. And they're musical, I could tell right away. They can carry a tune when they hear something. And I'm thinking about myself, you know, at what age did I start thinking about the music and considering music and whatever. And I remembered that I learned "Pennies From Heaven" [sings] every time it rains it rains — to this day I mean I know the words very well — directly connected back to when I was six or seven. And so I used to go to the movies on Saturday morning for a nickel in those days, you know, in Martin's Ferry, Ohio, Bellaire, Ohio, way far away like that. Steel mines and coal mines and a lot of the immigrant bohunks you know and all that kind of stuff. Polacks and Italians. So I used to go to the movies. I might have seen it there, and maybe I heard it on the radio. My parents at that time didn't have a gramophone, so I learned "Pennies From Heaven" because I liked it and my ear. And the words and all. And they used to stand me up, that's the only one I remember, stand me up onto the chair, like seven years old, and I would perform.

MR: You'd do that song.

JM: You know so I said gee, I guess I must have a calling — I'm not saying a great calling — but it must mean something to me. And so as a kid I was very aware of music. I heard the Hungarian music, you know, my parents used to go to dances and balls and picnics and they'd have a gypsy band. And that I liked. I mean I just listened. It didn't occur to me that it was different or funny or anything, I'd listen and I was just open to it. And I found that I enjoyed most the bass player. And they had like a German bow, you know, you put your fingers right in it? The frog you know, it looked about like that. It comes down and they put their fingers in at the end of it.

MR: Um, they really grab it.

JM: Yeah. Zoom — zoom — zoom. And I'd just stand in front of them and I enjoyed that so much. And I'll tell you there's a funny thing. You ever hear of a trombone player named Cutty Cutshall?

MR: Sure.

JM: I knew Cutty. I played with him you know, more than a few times at the Eddie Condon's in midtown in the 50s. And somehow we got onto this. And it turns out he was from eastern Pennsylvania or something like that, you know I was born in Martin's Ferry, which is on the Ohio River down the river from Pittsburgh a hundred miles or not even that. And he was from that area, and he too, even though he didn't have the Hungarian background, he too loved the gypsy bands and the bass player going zoom — zoom — zoom. So it was a funny kind of thing.

MR: You would have been pretty young during the Depression.

JM: Oh yeah.

MR: Do you have any recollection of that being a particularly hard time for your family or your neighborhood?

JM: Yeah well you know my parents were immigrants and we were poor but I didn't know it. My mother was such a handy housekeeper and she cooked and cleaned and baked, and you know it was just sort of — and my father was a steel worker, he worked in the steel mill and stuff, and that was, I remember that was the era of the unions organizing you know, which was very critical. I mean today I know maybe unions are considered Mafia run and all that, but in my estimation there's a great room in America for labor unions and what labor unions do. And so I remember when I had a friend who was very teary and crying and he said one day his father had been beaten to death by company goons with a baseball bat, because they wanted to strike or something like that. So I remember that and I remember my father was out on the left wing you know. I remember that he was very involved in politics in the sense of voting for somebody or campaigning for somebody you know. And there was a famous — well to me a famous — governor Davey I think it was, I don't know I think in the 30s. And there was a lot of campaigning against him. And he had some sort of tar road plan and so on. And somehow he had something to swindle about tarring, making asphalt roads or whatever you know. So yes, I have a very strong and vivid memory of the Depression and to this day I love old movies made as contemporary movies in the 30s, and the earlier the better. They're very interesting because they reflect the time. And I get that feeling from them.

MR: Were your parents wanting you to get a trade, a craft that would make a nice life for you?

JM: Well that develops — I was going to take accordion lessons from my father — not my father, a friend of my father's, some Italian guy. And I never got to handle an accordion ever, and I took lessons for three or four months. It was all solfeggio on a grand scale and

all of that, you know, it was like I'm dying to get my hands on something. So I don't know what happened.

MR: Oh you mean you were taking lessons and you never even got to play one for a while.

JM: Yeah, yeah, yeah. I don't remember if I had solfeggio or singing, maybe, but it was grand staff, the do-re-me-fa-so-la-C and all that kind of stuff, and I guess I sort of forgot it because — I don't know, maybe it had some early — and then I was going to take violin lessons. There was a guy named Pragia who came from Cleveland. And I don't think he was a gypsy, he was just sort of a very artistic, very, a fairly young guy with pale skin and very delicate fingers and was a hell of a violin player. And I had like one lesson or something or two lessons, and he was letting me hold it and things like that, and he stopped coming to Martin's Ferry. I think he had like a route he'd do, he'd come and teach the Hungarian community, and he'd teach kids. So he disappeared so that was that. So they wanted a musical education for me, they didn't want me to be a musician particularly. They were good parents. My father wasn't a drunk or you know, like he was a respectable family man, he had to provide for his family. And later on when I was a teenager he wanted me to be an electrician. He had a friend that was an electrician in the union and he could have gotten me into the union at age 17 or 18 or whatever like that, which is like guaranteeing you a lifetime income you know. And I wasn't interested, no I was interested in music, and that didn't appeal to me you know. Idiot. I always wondered what would have happened had I done it. I think I still would have been musical you know. As a young musician's life, as we all know, is not the most secure in general.

MR: That's true. So what was the first sort of jazz-related music that caught your ear?

JM: Well this is very interesting. If you're sensitive to music, as I was and am and hope to be for many more years, in that environment in Ohio there, in the 30s, there was no T.V. of course, there was radio and records. I was exposed to this Hungarian music, you know, which swings you know. Gunter Schuller says you know, that jazz music swings. Jazz is the only one — no, no. Hungarian music, you know, even Romanians even, I mean talk about swing. Anyhow —

MR: Does it have the, doing the off-beats two and four?

JM: No, no, no.

MR: But it has a groove to it.

JM: It's just, you hear it. There's nothing but rhythm going on. I still have some Romanian LPs you know. It's outasight. It's a sense of rhythm and you know like odd tempos in seven and five and you know. Well so anyhow, I was exposed to this Hungarian music. And then I was exposed to the swing era, you know swing music, the big bands you know, that business [scats] sophisticated swing you know. I have a vivid memory of walking through a carnival kind of thing, an outdoor thing, with my mother, late at night.

Maybe we were walking to go home or something, I don't know how. And over the P.A. system came that. And I liked that, and I said yeah. Years later when I heard it I said ooh I know that. So I was exposed to swing, I was exposed to Hungarian music, and then in that area there was a station, WWVA, and it had the equivalent of Grand Ole Opry. And on Saturday a midnight jamboree or something you know. And they had country players and fiddles and banjos and stuff. And so I had that influence. And so that was country-western. And then of course the Bing Crosby, the pop. Not swing but the pop tunes.

MR: Yeah, the "Pennies From Heaven" type of songs.

JM: Yeah, yeah, yeah. So it was all around me, and I wasn't necessarily in the cradle of the blues or anything like that. But that's a funny one. I mean you'll hear young black guys, I have my own ideas about the origin of jazz, I don't think it's black. It's not a black music, it's an American music. There was always white and Irishmen and Italians and stuff. And if you're black and you want to be proud about your black rhythm, that's marvelous, that's great, some of the greatest were you know. Joe Oliver, Louis Armstrong, Johnny Dodds. So but anyhow what was I saying? Oh so the midnight jamboree, and all that kind of music, and as a matter of fact my kid singing I continued with that, and they had an amateur contest on WWVA. And really, and I went to it, they had an audition at the amateur contest. And I go down with my mother and, you know we have no music or anything like that, and it was like something from "Our Gang."

MR: Like "Our Gang," yeah.

JM: And there was a row of kids with their mothers.

MR: All dressed up probably?

JM: Yeah, yeah, yeah. There was a skinny little red-haired girl, she might have had freckles even, she was singing and she had a violin you know. And it came her turn, and in the 30s it was [scats]. Benny Goodman made a record of it, it was a pop tune [scats].

MR: Okay.

JM: You never heard of it, huh?

MR: Not that one, no.

JM: But it's on a discography, Benny made a record and others. Bad thing. And so this little girl [screeches scats] well you could fall on the floor, even when I was a kid I said, "boy that's pretty terrible," scratching I mean. So we all did the thing, and I made the auditions. And I sang on the radio twice, can you imagine? Now I don't remember whether it was the Amateur Hour program or whether they put the winning amateurs on some bigger program. But the strange thing was — what did I sing and how did I pick it? I haven't the vaguest. [sings] "There's a goldmine in the sky far away/we will find it you and I some sweet day." Nick Kenny, you ever hear of Nick Kenny?

MR: No.

JM: Nick Kenny, he was a columnist in the news or something and he wrote lyrics for songs. And this was one of his, it's a sentimental thing, goldmine — and the other one was "There's a goldmine in the sky far away." So I sang them.

MR: Did you have an accompanist?

JM: Somebody played. Oh yeah, they had a piano player I guess. There was accompaniment. I wasn't alone. But when I think of it I was just seven or eight. And that was sort of bizarre. And I very rarely run through this in my mind, and connecting it to later things, you know. So it started then. And then I kept singing and then my parents left Ohio — not professionally or anything, just amateur. My father had — I had only one uncle, my uncle John. And my father was sort of on the square side and John was the direct opposite, a hellion. Women loved him. Very handsome. He looked like Clark Gable sort of. And he was with a Hungarian dance company. And he sang and danced professionally. And the first time he heard me sing "Pennies From Heaven" he comes up to me and he says you know that thing you sang in there? That's not in the song. I said well I just sort of like that.

MR: You were already improvising.

JM: I did a little something, but he caught me on it. And to myself I said well I don't care what he thinks, it sounds okay to me. But so he was musical so there must have been some musical feeling on my father's side, on my father's side of the family. Time went by, we moved to New York, and my mother I guess was a show biz mother in her own way, you never figure to think about it, but we came to New York and she somehow found a studio or something that gave kids vocal lessons and it was on Broadway — getting to the big time — Broadway, 52nd, 51st, 53rd Street. You go upstairs you know, and I went up there was a woman, and I don't know whether she played the piano or whether it was a guy that played the piano, and we sang songs. And I remember I had the sheet music for [sings] You are the promised kiss of springtime — you know that thing.

MR: "All the Things You Are."

JM: So I sang through that. So I mean isn't that funny, I had to re-learn that many a time.

MR: Do we need to stop, Tim?

TH: Yes, please. I need to move this. When you shift you're getting pinched here and I'm going to bring this around the others side.

MR: Yeah that's a tricky tune.

JM: Yeah I mean it's got very nice changes, but you've really got to know them. I've been on the rocks more than once with it.

MR: Yeah, right.

JM: At Jimmy Ryan's. I mean Bobby Pratt, the wonderful trombone player and piano player, he played the hell out of it with Roy Eldridge you know like that, he knew the sucker.

MR: Right. So you did "All the Things You Are." It does have that, getting about halfway through it's got that —

JM: Oh yeah, yeah [scats] it goes somewhere else.

MR: It goes somewhere else.

JM: Are we on the air?

TH: Yup.

JM: So I did that, and I don't remember particularly performing as performing, but I was taking these lessons, you know, maybe a couple of years of once a week or once every two weeks you know. And I did it and I don't know what it cost but they had to pay money you know. And my father was not making a lot of money, it was Depression times you know. And then my father belonged to a lodge in the Bronx. We lived in the Bronx. And they had a band, a small band. And they were looking for recruits. So — what was her name, there was a little Eva or Emma, something or other. And they were Hungarians you know. And she cornered me and said what did I want to play — would I like to join the band. I said well —. She said, "what would you like to play, the tuba?" You know.

MR: Yeah they needed a tuba, right?

JM: Yeah, like that. I said no. I never thought of it. No, no, no. She said well trumpet? And she said clarinet? And you know I must have been pretty hip already or something, but I immediately thought of Artie Shaw or Benny Goodman. "Yeah, the clarinet." It's very funny you know. And Woody Herman. I knew Woody Herman a little and I told him this story. And I said you're one of the guys responsible. Matter of fact I told Benny Goodman too. You're one of the guys responsible for me.

MR: Really?

JM: And I met Artie Shaw, I knew Artie Shaw a little you know. I never told him but I believe with that sort of thing you've got to tell people. So it was clarinet. And her name was List, I forget his first name, Mr. List I called him. Very nice man. He was sort of like the violin teacher , slight, pale, very musical. I don't know what he played. But he was a very good teacher in that he taught me fingerings. I mean to this day, you know, the high notes and everything. You know like really correct. The alternates, and how to get around. As a matter of fact I remember, this is very funny, that I played the Carters' inaugural with the World's Greatest Jazz Band. And it was a Duke Ellington band, it wasn't the real band, it was like the band after the band after the band. As a matter of fact while we were performing for Jimmy Carter I guess it was, they had a fist fight in the band.

MR: Oh good.

JM: In Duke's band and God knows what. And the clarinet player comes to me after the thing and he says, "how do you finger a high G?" And I showed him I mean. But certainly Mr.

List was a very good teacher. But I went home and I had a clarinet, it costs 25 bucks. And we paid it off a dollar a week or two dollars a week or something like that. And I wasn't an instant success with it because I went home and I was going to master this sucker you know. And I had a younger sister —I had, she's passed on — and she was musical, she danced. She did Hungarian folk dancing, really good. And as a matter of fact her teacher was this old lady, it was Mrs. Serly, and her son was Tibor Serly, who finished the Bartok whatever it is, you know, there was a guy, Tibor Serly finished I think the Bartok Concerto or something. When Bartok died before it was finished he finished it. And he used to play piano for their dancing. Remember him, I said, you know who that was? Well anyway, where was I?

MR: How did you make your first dollar with your clarinet?

JM: Oh, oh, oh. Well this is very deep. So anyhow, well let me finish the story about my sister. So I went home with the clarinet and I started to practice and she laughed and said "you sound like a duck," which led me to practice. And I evidently improved very quickly. I mean I just ate it up. So then I ended up in high school and I played in the high school band. And I never got into athletics much, you know, football. "You'd make a good football player" you know. I wanted to play the clarinet. So my first dollar with the clarinet, would you believe, was a gig in Trenton, New Jersey and the bass player was Pops Foster. It was a bowling alley in Trenton, New Jersey. I think it paid a lot of money, like 35 bucks or something, which was a lot of money.

MR: Apiece?

JM: Yeah.

MR: That's a lot of money at that time.

JM: Yeah, well when was it, late 40s, 50s? Well late 40s I guess. And it was a very funny one because we were in this place and we go down, there's a restaurant in the place, in the bowling alley, and we're going to have something to eat. And it was Pops Foster. And I knew who he was, I loved him and I respected him you know. And he looks at the menu and he said, "is this every tub?" I said, "Pops, what's every tub?" "Oh," he says, "don't you know what that means?" I said, "no." He said, "every tub on its own bottom, do we pay or does the boss pay?" And then you know there's a King Oliver record called "Every Tub."

MR: Sure there is. And a Basie record too.

JM: Yeah, yeah. And there's — I think I heard Louis Armstrong say a couple of times, you know an ensemble when you start playing? "Every tub." You know, it'd be every guy on his own, you know, going to improvise.

MR: So he meant everybody was paying for their own food?

JM: Everybody on his own.

MR: Everybody on his own.

JM: By every tub means every tub on its own bottom. Everybody on his own.

MR: That's cool.

JM: Okay? And that could apply to paying or it could apply to improvising. You know we're not going to read music or don't play the melody, unison. Improvise, yeah.

MR: Right. That's great. I love learning that lingo.

JM: Oh there's many things. And I have sort of a historical and scientific — not deeply historical because I love history, it was my favorite subject in school. But I remember the little details. I'm an encyclopedia about pulling teeth. I connect one thing to another and I love that every tub thing. Because it carried all the way through to Louis Armstrong you know. So anyhow, that was in Trenton. I'm trying to think — there's a guy named Irving Kratka, played the drums. He started a record label, what was it?

MR: Oh Inner City Records.

JM: Yeah, and "Music Minus One."

MR: Irv Kratka? I'll be darned.

JM: Yeah.

MR: "Music Minus One."

JM: That was my idea.

MR: Oh get out.

JM: It was, yeah. I started a record company with him and then, well it's too long a story. But I made a list of possible ideas for a small record company that the big ones aren't doing so much, and that was one of them. I mean who would have known? I mean he actually followed it through, but it was something a small company could do that bigger ones don't. So anyhow the music continues and you know I still consider myself a musician, I mean that's what I've been doing for the sole of my existence for a long time now. And I am odd in that my generation usually by this time has been playing bebop for a long time. You know, and they sort of came up in the late big band era, playing saxophone or something in a big band and then went on, you know, and the lingua franca of the day was bebop. You know? Swing wasn't that strong. But I didn't come up that way. You know I'm too young to have been part of the scene in the 30s to play in the big bands, and I am an old revivalist. You know after World War II there were the moldy figs, the ones that were interested in old records and King Oliver and Jelly Roll Morton and that kind of stuff, you know going back to the original. That was me. I loved that. And so in high school I belonged to the Brooklyn Tech Jazz Society and we'd bring in records and I junk shopped you know, and nothing was available, Monk. Today it's like the computer — you can get everything, even that Red Hot Jazz Archive you can go on, you know that?

MR: Um hum.

JM: You know there it is, I would have killed for those records and you just click on them. How were you going to get them?

MR: Did it make it more precious for you?

JM: Yes.

MR: Because it was something you had to really aspire to get and figure out how to get and carry the 78s home and all that stuff.

JM: Oh yeah. Junk shopping I remember I was in Washington, D.C. I went to the Army Air Corps, which became the Air Force just as I left, band school. In Bolling Field. And my uncle, Uncle John, the musical one, lived there and his wife was a nurse there at St. Elizabeth or something. And Anacostia was there, the big black neighborhood. And I remember one day I went out and it was unbelievable, there were like rarity, like treasures. God I went out and I found a Johnny Dodds Paramount record in very good shape. You could see Dixieland Thumpers and I found a Freddie Keppard record. I mean, and it was a gold mine. And New York had been picked out. There were a lot of big collectors here you know, they had been picked out and were very hard to find anymore. But I did, I even went door to door, you know in the black neighborhoods in the afternoon, "I'm looking for old records, have you any old records?" Sometimes I found them.

MR: You're kidding.

JM: So it was very precious.

MR: Wow. And you got to play during your military service, you got to continue to play?

JM: Oh yeah, yeah. So I played in the band and then it was like, I think it was like 1946 or something, and I graduated high school and it was a matter of — when I joined the Air Force the war was still on. The war didn't technically end until '47 or something, by treaty or whatever. So I enlisted in '46 and I'm a veteran of World War II 'cause the war was still on. But I was going to get drafted. They were still drafting then, they hadn't changed that law. So I don't know why — I mean I was always, I'm not a bad businessman but I'm not ahead, I'm not. And somehow I got the information that if you enlisted for three years, and then you would get the GI bill and you could go to college. And if you enlisted then you could pick what you wanted to be. So I enlisted and I wanted to be a bandsman. I was promised that so I enlisted. And I'd go to San Antonio, Texas for, and even then I junk shopped and I found some records. I went over — there's a river in San Antonio and a couple of waterfalls. I almost went over one of the waterfalls in my khaki outfit with a rowboat or something.

MR: Oh really.

JM: But anyhow, and talking about career choices — will I be an electrician or not — so there I am and I took all the exams and stuff. And one day Private Marino or whatever they called me — "yeah." "You've got to go down to headquarters." And I thought what did I do? As a matter of fact I did do something when they trained us. You know, hip — hip — hip to the left, right, right oblique, all that kind of stuff. And okay, cigarette break, 15 minutes or something. And we'd all sit down. And I pulled out a book, I'm reading a book, and the sergeant comes over. "What the F are you doing?" I said, "I'm reading a book." He said, "you're not allowed to read a book, you've got to smoke a cigarette." I said, "I don't smoke." And you know the next day there was a general order on the bulletin board that there will be no reading of books during —. So anyhow, and there were all like rebels, you know, like it was the end of the world. Southerners and you know, from the back woods and all that kind of stuff. So, "Muranyi — Private Muranyi." I go down, so and so and so, sit down and the officer said, "yes." There's a guy, an officer, got a folder with my name. He says, "you know you have a very high IQ." And I'm flattered, you know, I said, "well yeah, okay." I'd had tests before and they rated pretty good. And I had gone to Brooklyn Tech which is still to this day considered a very good high school. And I did pretty good. I mean I flunked one of the math courses. It was almost calculus was what it was and *non mi piace* — I didn't like it. Anyhow so he says, "you know, we're always looking for bright young men" he says, "how would you like to go to cryptography school?" So I says, "oh no, no, no, no." I want to be a clarinet player. I was promised that MOS — military occupation specialty — 508 or whatever it was. And he said, "you know it wouldn't be bad, we'd send you to Washington and etcetera, etcetera you know. And I said no, no. And I always thought suppose I had said yes.

MR: That's like figuring out codes and all that.

JM: Yeah, yeah. I'd be probably a CIA guy or something. Isn't that funny? I mean I know it was a choice you know. So I was put into the band and I was stationed in Westover Field in Springfield, Mass in a Military Air Transport Command — MATS. And I played in the band and they ran the — you know from Westover they used to go to Germany, I can't think of the name of it, it's still there, the Air Force base. Wiesbaden, and then there was the name of a Air Force base. And they'd go back and forth and stuff. And they even had a choice of that, did I want to go. I should have done that too. In Germany after the war would be very nice you know, I'd probably speak some German you know, probably would have grabbed some German chick for all I know. But anyhow, I played in a band and had a wonderful time. And I was there for three years, I made Sergeant, and they promised me Staff Sergeant if I re-upped and I went no, I hated the Army. But I was the band librarian and I had some decision on what we were going to play, with the First Sergeant who conducted, Sergeant Baraka was a doll. And I remember on my birthday,

he knew my birthday, I was invited to his house for dinner. And there I am and I didn't drink at the time, maybe I had a beer or something, and he starts playing these V-disks, and he had Lester Young's [scats], what is that?

MR: Right. I'll think of that in a moment.

JM: Yeah, yeah, "I Got Rhythm" you know. A twelve inch V-disk. He played that for me and a couple of other things you know. It was very nice. So I had a very good time. And that's when I started to play jazz. They had sort of a big band, and I didn't want to play saxophone. I took I think clarinet lessons from the local symphony guy on my own and I didn't want to play saxophone. I was going to be a legitimate clarinet player. And that's what I played in the military band, I became the first clarinetist. There was one guy, an old guy, Rutherford, Al Rutherford, a juicer you know. He had a little red nose. He was a marvelous player. I mean you know the military band, they have a lot of transcriptions, you know, Verdi and things like that, where the clarinets play the violin parts, page after page. [scats]. You've got to read, and you know, they could do that. They've got a band sound for solos, so I would get the cadenzas and stuff you know, which was, I think, that's when I made my first record in the sense that they had a — we used to do radio programs and somebody transcribed some of them you know, and there was one I used to have where I played a little written clarinet solo but it was sort of a jazzy kind of thing. And so then I started fooling around with improvisation and I was terrible. I played a lot of red notes you know, out of the chord.

MR: A lot of red notes.

JM: They had a sort of, I played, they had sort of a small combo but I was interested in antique music, you know, "Muskrat Ramble" and Louis Armstrong Hot Fives and Sevens.

MR: Yeah. Not "Lester Leaps In."

JM: Lester was sort of past then, but it was my favorite, you know I like the old stuff. And so I didn't do much with the dance band. I think I played a little flute, lousy flute, and a little solo on something. But so what I did was by that time I'm in New York and I'm starting to play, and I got in with a crowd, you know a crowd of guys like my age and maybe a couple of guys from the Jazz Club in Brooklyn. And what happened was there used to be a Lindy's or whatever it was called, it was on Broadway, high 40s, above Times Square, and above that was Nola's.

MR: Nola's Studio.

JM: They're on 57th if they're still around. But I rehearsed there with Louis Armstrong. So anyhow the Nola's Studio, you could rent. You could rent a room, it had a piano, and the deal was everybody would kick in some money, two, three dollars, whatever it was, and rent a room for an hour or two hours, and have a jam session. And we did that. And there

was, you know, really feeling our way and a part of that scene was Bob Wilber. That's where I first met Bob Wilber. Bob Wilber, by the way, looks much better today than he did then. He was a skinny —

MR: I've seen pictures, yeah.

JM: Skinny, pale, with sort of bad hair, wavy, curly hair you know. And he looked like a nerd. But he played wonderfully. I said Jesus Christ he scared me to death. And I was sort of like, in retrospect I was sort of a nature boy, you know, with the red notes and a lot of wails and wooo. Soulful. You're trying to imitate Johnny Dodds. I mean I didn't — I liked Benny Goodman but I didn't aspire to that kind of clarinet that I wanted to play. But Johnny Dodds was my hero for a long time.

MR: Sidney Bechet?

JM: I liked Sidney, yeah. I liked Sidney a lot and then not later on I fell in love with Omer Simeon, the clarinet player with Jelly Roll Morton and he played with Wilbur DeParis you know on 52nd Street. So now I get into college, and even then I'm improvising and playing little gigs and stuff and I joined the Phi Mu Alpha Symphonia, you know, a fraternity, and part of the test initiation was you had to improvise, you had to play at a jam session. And everybody was terrible, well they were all classical musicians you know. And we had this thing and I'm wailing away, and they're looking, "what the hell? Where'd you get that?" You know it was completely unexpected. I was going to become a music teacher. So where were we? So that's how I started to play. And I think after, with the crowd I was with that was with Irv Kraken who was a trumpet player. There was a guy named Jerry Bloomberg. Jerry was a wonderful player. He was sort of like, he loved Bunk Johnson, and he could play like Bunk very much, you know, he was quite a good player. He maybe — and you know who maybe was on it? The guy, the short guy that played trombone some with Louis' big band. He played with Clarence Williams in the 20s. I can't think of his name. He was on it too. So I did that, and that was my first gig as I said that paid some money. And then I was scratching around. There used to be a joint in Bridgeport, Connecticut called the Tip Toe Inn. And they paid some sort of $20 and drinks or whatever, which didn't interest me much. I didn't smoke or anything, you know. And the pot was around, but I was not interested in that. It was years later that I smoked a joint you know. Oh no. So you know, getting into the musical world such as it was, so we played this gig in Bridgeport and it was always trouble. There was a union guy would come around and see — I think he was really interested in the tax you know, which is really all he ever wanted, to see your card you know. So it was a big — I think I joined the union, I joined the union when it was on I think 54th and Sixth. And I went up and they put up music, I read it and I got my card. I mean there were other guys who went up there and they couldn't play at all. Bob Green, the piano player, told me there

was a piano player and they put music in front of him and he played some Jelly Roll Morton thing. And they said, "you're not reading the music." He said, "well this is my interpretation." He got in.

MR: Yeah. The audition wasn't that official.

JM: Yeah. It showed the corruption of the union in those days. And that building on the corner there, 54th or 52nd and Sixth, wherever it was, they could have bought for something like $50,000, which would be worth a billion dollars today you know. They could have had a permanent home and they didn't buy it they just kept renting it. Probably somebody got a kickback you know.

MR: Well let me skip up a little bit, you worked as a producer for RCA and Atlantic?

JM: Yeah. Let me see what happened. I got out of college and I played in a college band called the Red Onions and we used to play Jimmy Ryan's on Monday nights alternating with Wilbur DeParis, where Omer Simeon played. I got to know Omer and he played an Albert system to hell. Hardly had any keys on it. It was like, I don't know how he played. And so I got him a Buffet. Somebody gave me one and I gave it to him, or he gave me 20 bucks for it or something. I really wanted the horn myself but I couldn't stand him, he was this great guy playing — and you know he was just so facile. He made that thing, the "Russian Rag" [scats] playing this thing on this primitive clarinet. So I loved him. His licks and everything, he was very influential on me. So that's college. And I graduate, and I had a friend, also in part of this scene you know, the jam sessions and all that, a guy named Dick Hadlock. And Dick was on the west coast. He studied soprano with Bechet, with Sidney in Brooklyn. And Dick's still got a radio program out there in San Francisco for years. Very nice guy. He wrote that book "Jazz Masters of the Twenties." You know that? Dick is very knowledgeable. He knows almost as much as I do. I'm kidding of course. But he's a grand guy. I love him. I mean he's the sweetest, gentlest, knowledgeable. And he was working at RCA. And, at RCA International. And he wanted — they were going to expand the department and they were looking for somebody and they asked me was I interested. I said well I don't know. I was going to be a music teacher but I student taught for two semesters and I hated it, I didn't like it at all. So I got the job at RCA. And I enjoyed that very much, it was very good. It was very funny, there was a thing, it was RCA Victor, okay? That was the name of the American RCA company, they bought the — RCA bought Victor. When Sarnoff had the big hit with the radios in the late 20s or something they bought the Victor talking machine company and they became RCA Victor. And so their trademark, the dog and the phonograph and all that, and they had a deal with the English His Master's Voice, the same trademark. You know France Le Vois DeMetre, you know, the same logo. And in those days the government was more efficient on such things, and I wonder why. But they were notified,

RCA, that it was a trust, a worldwide trust, you're not allowed to have — one company controlling the whole world, you know, the competition. You've got to break it up. So Sarnoff decided, for legal reasons, they were going to create an RCA label and never mind the Victor and the dog and phonograph, to show that they really are competing against the English Victor talking machine, whatever. And so the RCA label was started. And Dick and I were in charge of that and we put together — it was great fun to put together a catalogue, you know, like what shall we have. We picked, you know, I succeeded, and Brian Rust said some little tale about it, but Benny Moten "South" was a record made in the 20s, and that was continually in RCA's catalogue until the end of the 78 RPM era, 'til '45, an all-time best seller of some kind you know. So we made sure to put that in the catalogue, and all that kind of stuff. And it was just great fun you know, with the record business. Our boss was a guy named Frank McCall. And I got to talking with Frank McCall, he was a nice guy you know, smoking a cigar and pulling his hair out. And he used to work for Frank Walker in the 20s, and Frank Walker was the recording director at Columbia Records and he recorded Bessie Smith. And he told me this marvelous story about that Bessie was trying to suck up to Frank Walker and came in one day in Philadelphia with a bicycle and that still had the price on it, and she gave it to him to give to his daughter.

MR: I'll be darned.

JM: But can you imagine — a Bessie Smith story direct. And then there was a guy, Jack Linderman was the head of — he was recording in Brazil, in Rio, for RCA. And I got to talking to him too one time and he said he was an engineer or in charge of recording in Camden, New Jersey. I said, "yeah?" I said, "you ever encounter Louis Armstrong?" He said, "yes, I was present at all those RCA Victor sessions." You know? And he said they were done in a little church in Camden, and he said one day they had a thing, there was a fireplace that was blocked up and something happened and the blockage exploded. And the whole Louis Armstrong session was ruined on account of the soot came out and covered the walls. And I treasure those stories, you know, it's a direct contact. And there was an old gal, Phoebe Snow, who was in charge of purchasing or something, and she's got an invoice on the wall. And she went to them and she said well that's from the 20s and it's a bill from the something Button and Lacquer Corporation to Victor Talking Machine Company because that's what they pressed the records out of.

MR: Oh Lacquer and—

JM: You know, like button lacquer or something. But she told me some stories about Jimmie Rodgers, you know the country singer? And how much of a junkie he was you know. Some of his records were made in hotel rooms with people holding him up by the side.

MR: Did the advent of rock & roll change the amount of work you would get either as a player or —

JM: Well now it certainly has, I mean that whole thing developed. I remember when I worked at RCA there was a guy named Steve Sholes and he was involved in pop A&R. And there was ads on Billboard and all sort of back and forth. And he signed Elvis Presley for $50,000, a lot of money in those days. Ten million bucks or more or who knows what it would be today. And it was like his ass was on the line, he said he better produce or his job is gone. It was such a — RCA was a conservative company, you know. And of course you know what happened.

MR: I guess it worked.

JM: Yeah, yeah. But you know what happened, Monk, was that around New York, a big city like this, you know rent was fairly cheap, not like today, you know. The trouble with New York today is there are too many people with too much money. And in those days rent was reasonable, a lot of little restaurants, clubs, bars, bars would have little bands. Weekends if nothing else. Or Ryan's started as a bar, that went on for years, that wasn't supposed to be a jazz nightclub or anything. So that just sort of all disappeared. And nothing has replaced it. And T.V. killed a lot of this stuff. You know why go into a local bar and have a few beers and listen to the band when you can see the famous names and Milton Berle on television. So I think everything has mitigated against live jazz. I mean live jazz was associated ad infinitum, ad nauseum, way back with a club and drinking and dancing. You know, I mean times have changed and they're changing around. But right now in New York there aren't that many jazz clubs.

MR: And it costs a lot to go to them often times.

JM: Yes, yes.

MR: Well tell me how the gig with Louis Armstrong happened for you.

JM: Well a break in the night. I knocked around for a while and you know, you get to know people that are similarly inclined, you know, your kind of jazz. And I got to know George Wettling. There was a guy named Dick Webb, the trombone player, he was the editor of *Boating* magazine. A very nice trombone player and a darling guy, he was the greatest guy in the world, quite a sailor, I used to do a lot of sailing with him. And Dick knew George Wettling and I lived in the Village and George Wettling lived a block or two away from me. And somehow we met and we hit it off. George was a great guy, he was wonderful. He got drunk, and I heard he got nasty, but he never did that with me. He never had any kids and I was like a son. And I liked the music. And so he got me together with Condon and Wild Bill and that group, and McPartland. He was a very good friend of Jimmy McPartland. So I got to play with Jimmy McPartland and got on the scene, and Jimmy, and Marian is still around, a wonderful gal. And I think the first time I made

more than $100, it was $150, was with Jimmy McPartland and we had to drive to Cleveland and back. And I went on the road with him too. And the Dixieland and that old tradition, that old time Chicago jazz, it continued in Ohio in Columbus and Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania, and places like that, they had clubs and the people were still interested in that kind of music. So I got all involved in that and things went along and went along. I played with this one and that one and there was a guy named Max Amayer, a booking agent sort of. And he called me a couple of times, three or four times, to play with Red Allen which was a wonderful experience. Red was a marvelous guy. I mean Red was up there with Louis Armstrong. Red Allen was just a natural — you listen to those old records. You get tired of playing Louis all the time. A little refreshing change is Red Allen. So I played with Red and then there was a scene called Stuyvesant Casino where Bunk Johnson came. That was the first live jazz band almost that I saw, certainly the first black New Orleans band. Bunk Johnson at the Stuyvesant. I was there opening night. As a matter of fact there are some photographs. I saw them in Japan in some magazine about Bunk Johnson's opening night and there I am.

MR: You were in one of them?

JM: You could see me with my first wife, we were still going together. She's sitting on my knee and we're smiling listening to Bunk Johnson. It's a marvelous thing. So I liked it, and I got to know George Lewis rather well. And he hated Bunk Johnson and the whole band hated Bunk. It was like — and George Lewis was such a gentle, sweet guy. But I remember we were in a men's room once and Bunk's name came up and he just — Bunk Johnson — you wouldn't believe that George could get that nasty with those kind of words. I mean that's how much he disliked Bunk.

MR: Well they were probably thrown together with him because he had so much hype going on, rediscovered, you know, working in the fields, and they got new teeth and all.

JM: Well Bunk was a marvelous musician. Bunk used to call that whole band, Jim Robinson and George Lewis and [Lawrence] Marrero and what's the name of the piano player, [Alton] Pernell, his wartime emergency band. Because Bunk was a great trumpet player. And I listened to that band critically, I loved the whole sound. But after a while I realized that, Jim Robinson especially, would play through changes, you know [scats] chord changes. Swinging, nice tone and everything and exciting, but he wasn't making the changes. And George Lewis played out of tune. I loved him, he has a wonderful nice approach, but he wasn't in the league with an Omer Simeon or Johnny Dodds or Bechet. Same idea but you know. So I got to know that band and I liked him. As a matter of fact in later years when I first went to New Orleans with Louis Armstrong I got a word from Allan Jaffe, the guy that ran Preservation Hall, that, "George wants to see you." And George, when I first met him in New York he was a mild guy, I think he was afraid to

talk to white people. It was, you know, he came from such a different milieu, you know. I mean it was bad days down there you know. And George once says, isn't that nice, I'm touched, you know. And so we meet him in the Quarter somewhere and we're going to go to a funeral. There's George in a nice suit, Panama hat and a cigarette holder with a cigarette in it. This down home guy, right?

MR: Right and now he's in his own element.

JM: And we embraced and he's smiling, you know, it was the whole thing. He said I never thought I'd meet with Louis, and I forget what he said but it was sort of like he was taken with that you know. "Oh I have faith in you all the time." And years later when I was with Louis Armstrong and we were in San Francisco, we played a thing there, what's that San Francisco festival, I can't think. Sacramento.

MR: The Sacramento Jazz Festival.

JM: Yeah. We were there and Pops was on that, Pops Foster. And backstage he comes up to me and grabs me and there I am playing with Louis Armstrong, his old buddy. It was wonderful. I had some wonderful moments that way. So anyway I get into the milieu playing with this guy, that guy, you know, and I'm taking lessons. I took lessons with Lennie Tristano for a long time. And you know I didn't dislike modern jazz, I just couldn't do it. And so I used to buy all the records and try to keep up to date and all that kind of stuff but I realized a long time after that I really wasn't interested. My heart wasn't there. And why make myself play something that I, you know, it would be nice to be versatile, but even saxophone I started much too late. As a matter of fact Kenny Davern was a saxophone player first. And he played baritone. As a matter of fact the Nola Studios, there was a guy named Walter Bo in Brooklyn, a nice guy, plays the trumpet you know, black guy. Plays the trumpet and I've known him a thousand — he was a friend of Dick Hadlock, the guy I referred to him before, since he was 15 or something. And Walter loves traditional jazz. And when Kenny died he said, "hello, remember me, Walter?" I said, "yeah, Walter." He said, "when was the first time you met Kenny Davern?" "Jack Solmer's house," he used to play saxophone and clarinet around New York. He lived in Queens and his father was wealthy and I was invited to a jam session, and I said there. And I came in and Kenny was playing baritone sax and Jack said, "Kenny I'd like you to meet Joe Muranyi the clarinet player." And Kenny was younger you know, Kenny's younger than I. And he said, "no, no, no, that's not where you met Kenny Davern." He said, "it was at Nola Studios and I was having a session and you were playing, we were playing together," and he said, "we went upstairs because Ray Sinatra, he was a band leader in Las Vegas, he used to be anyhow when I was there with Louis, he was there, a nice cat I talked with him. He said he was some distant relative to Frank you know. He said, "Ray Sinatra's big band was rehearsing and I wanted to see

what it was and you came up with me, and who's playing baritone sax but Kenny Davern. And Kenny was interested in what we were doing and he came down and played his clarinet. And he said that's where you first met him. It's a long time ago. But I've got to tell you the truth, Kenny Davern was, very early on, a wonderful clarinet player. It was just, he was God given natural you know. I think that Bob Wilber is a great reed man too but I think Kenny is more creative.

MR: Very creative.

JM: More of a fire in him you know. And one of the reasons I like Kenny was you know Kenny didn't particularly care for bebop. He made something out of traditional jazz. It became an individual thing, which I like, which I try to do, I've tried to do all my life. And strangely enough I think I'm coming into, I think I'm getting better and better as I get older. It's not an illusion, I always am a strong critic of myself. And now I have moments that I feel good, I feel happy about what I played. You know I hear it back and I say yeah, that ain't bad. It still ain't where I want it to be but it's hard. You see, improvising, playing jazz is a very difficult thing. It's very difficult to be original and then you have to be your own person. You can copy choruses and do all kinds of things but that doesn't count. A clarinet player and I learn all the Benny Goodman things like Sol Yaged. So what? It's a fool's errand.

MR: I was wondering if you'd mention him.

JM: It's a fool's errand because somebody does it perfectly already. You can only suffer by the comparison you know. Not that I'm putting Sol down, I admire Sol. I remember Sol from when I was a kid seeing him play. He's lasted. He's a New York legend in his own way, not a giant but you know I mean in his own way. So what were we talking about?

MR: Well I'm curious, how do you explain to someone who is only familiar with jazz in the big sense, well what's traditional jazz as opposed to modern jazz?

JM: Okay Monk, you hit the nail — I've been working for years, I've got about 30 chapters in the computers about Louis Armstrong. And it's very rarely discussed. It's a very big problem of the music and it doesn't get discussed much — what is jazz? And it's a very difficult subject, and how do you define what is jazz. And I've tried, well it's swing. Well no, a lot of music swings. It's got soul, whatever. A lot of music has got soul. It's got to have — I think it's got to be a strong touch of the blues, some of the bended notes. It can't be, I think Buddy DeFranco for instance has warmed up a lot. About ten years ago I heard somebody say hey, that's really — I hear he is sort of phenomenal you know. But I didn't get much warmth out of him. This is kind of nice. I said, "really?" I was so pleased. Number one I was pleased that I liked it you know? Because I'm very tough. People ask me do you like — well something about jazz — what do you like? Do you like jazz? And I say no I don't like jazz, which is more true than the other that I like jazz.

Because most stuff that passes for jazz today I do not care for. I don't like it. And they've got a perfect right, they've got a right to play them blues but it doesn't interest me. Okay. So it boils down to what is jazz? It's got to have some blue notes, it's got to swing, it's got to be — it helps if it's original. It's sort of life generally it's got to be in a certain bag, you know what I mean? A certain form, bebop or whatever, however. But it's very hard to define. And I thought about it and thought about it and thought about it and for me jazz is the music that Louis Armstrong plays. It's very simple, you can understand, you know when I say that you know what I'm talking about don't you?

MR: I do until, but Louis Armstrong played a lot of music sort of after the 20s and 30s also that may not have been really jazz. He jazzed it up.

JM: Well his music, jazzing it up, what is jazz? Jazz is a feeling. You can play the straight — now Louis Armstrong, you know, he was the same man when he died as he was when he was young you know. That flame in him never died. And he could play the straight melody and melt your heart and that's jazz. You could tell the difference between somebody very square and somebody swinging you know.

MR: Yeah. I have a brief piece here of —

[audio interlude]

JM: Oh yeah. It's "Wonderful, Wonderful."

MR: Remember that session? I mean I'm amazed at how many records are out there.

JM: That was made on 57th Street here.

MR: Really.

JM: With, the guy that did Commodore Records, the A&R guy, can't think of his name.

MR: Grauer?

JM: No it wasn't Grauer. He's famous. He was A&R Decca. He recorded Billie Holiday and everything.

MR: Oh Avakian?

JM: No.

MR: Oh gee.

JM: He had Commodore Music up on 42nd Street and the Commodore Label.

MR: Oh yeah. This is like Billy Crystal's uncle.

JM: Oh that right. That's it. Jesus, isn't that terrible. Years ago I was so sharp and now I forget that sort of thing. But anyhow the point is he never lost it, Louis Armstrong. And now this gets into the definition very much, you made a good point there. You say well "Hello Dolly" time is, you know, it's certainly not as interesting as "Struttin' With Some Barbecue" or "Potato Head Blues," you know, naked creativity. The situation was completely different. But he never lost his fire. He always showed something. And what happens is like Roy Eldridge. I ended up playing at Ryan's with Roy Eldridge. I played

with Roy for ten, eleven years. And at the same time I was playing with Louis Armstrong. Would you believe that? Me, the immigrant's son? Ofay Joe? You know? And I got involved between them with the deepest S-H-I-T you know. And Zutty Singleton was involved in it you know. I got Zutty and Louis Armstrong together when Zutty had a stroke. I told Louis it's all — and remember he went to see Zutty and they hadn't been together for years and years you know. And it was like Pops was putting down — oh he can't play drums with us, etcetera. And he went to visit Zutty in the Woodburn Hotel over here. And you know Zutty had a lot of fans, Ahmet Ertegun liked him and Ahmet, you know he just died. And he said, "if you need anything" he said, "you call me, don't call your white friends" your rich white friends you know. There's a marvelous story about, and you know Louis, he was a saint. And it was the biggest thing in my life, and I'm going to get teary, I'm near to. He was a wonderful guy. And he could be a bastard and he could be, oh a terrible, he could hurt you so badly and nobody in the world could do that. But anyhow the point is I liked him and he liked me. And the thing is I've never yet, and you know I've talked to people for a hundred years, "you ever see Louis?" And you know you hear the most interesting things you know. And most everybody that got to know him or knew him a little, Louis was his best friend. You know Louis had this quality, Louis as he called himself, had this quality, he was very gregarious and very good with people and he liked people, and he would really go out of his way and you know you would think well the big man doesn't have time for that, but he did make time. And a lot of people thought that he was a much better friend than he was. Not that he wasn't a friend but he had this quality that he exuded.

MR: Sure. You felt like he was —

JM: So and I include myself. So when I say this, maybe I'm from — but he was awfully nice to me.

MR: What is "Louis' Lightbulb?"

JM: Oh yeah, yeah.

MR: Does this mean something?

JM: Yeah, yes, yes, yes, yes. I took my kids, my second wife and the two kids, Adrienne and Paul, and Paul was the little one. And we took them down to Atlantic City. We were playing there, to have them meet Louis Armstrong. So they came up on the stage, you know I took them back stage, and my daughter said, "it's nice to meet you Mr. Armstrong." She's the older one, she was very cute and darling. And my son Paulie must have been five or something like that. And Paul puts out his left hand because he was so ambiguous [sic] whether he was left or right handed, puts out his left hand. And Pops breaks up laughing and he puts out his left hand too. And he liked the kids you know. And they met him later on. We were in Reno once, at Wantlester in Reno. And we had

made some records with Pops. And he had a little phonograph. He always traveled with a phonograph, and enjoyed demos of the records. And he called me on the phone and he says, we're in the same motel, and he says, "you want to hear the record we made?" I said, "yeah, yeah." I said, "I'll send up Paul, my son." And I mean I'm just saying he didn't call everybody in the band and said do you want to hear the — you know what I mean? It was like, so I sent Paul up, and God 45 minutes, what happened to him, did he get lost? I'm starting to get nervous. And in walks Paul with the phonograph record. "Paul, where were you?" "Oh," he says, "I went up and the door was a little open and I knocked on the door and he let me in and he was sitting on the bed with his trumpet," tooting you know. So he called me in and he says, "you like the trumpet?" And Paul says, "yeah." Well a conversation ensued and then he said, "I sat on the bed next to him and he says 'you want to blow it?'" And I mean the old man fell in love with my son you know. He never had any kids you know what I mean? So I mean I remember a couple of nights in Reno and Pops was kind of bombed. We were at the blackjack table. And he starts on a monologue on me and my son: "boy he's got Joe Muranyi on clarinet man, he's got a son, you ought to see that little sucker." Whatever. It was darling. So anyhow he impressed Paul. And Paul and two of my daughters, they're both very artistic, my daughter's better but my son's pretty good. And for years Paul drew a head with teeth, a big smile. It was obviously Pops. And at the time I didn't pick up on it. It's this big smile and he called it "Louie Lightbulb." I mean it's like when Pops is around a light goes on. But it was so darling you know. That's the "Louie Lightbulb" story.

MR: Gee that's a neat story. Well you said in a little note you wrote to me, you said as far as your own career right now, you said thank God for Europe.

JM: Yeah.

MR: You go over there a lot?

JM: Yeah. I mean they have jazz, not everywhere, but generally jazz is considered more of a cultural thing, more art. And you know George Bernard Shaw or somebody said that if you travel and go to foreign countries that's the only time you get to know your own country you know. And America, I am an American, I love America, I was born here and went to school here you know. I served in the armed forces here as I said before. But there's an awful lot — America's not perfect you know. There are a lot of traits America has that — we're just so big you know that we don't take criticism easily. And there are many aspects. So in Europe, I think jazz is getting less there too than it is here, frankly I think rock has taken over. But I find that I'm more appreciated and I get more work and more surprising — I walk down a small street in Hungary or something and everybody knows in the street who I am. And it's not, I don't know what that is but it makes you feel

good. And I'm not expecting people to stop in the street, who am I after all, a clarinet player. But I get a much better feeling out of Europe, being a musician there.

MR: You expressed some feelings about jazz education before we started today.

JM: Jazz what?

MR: Jazz education?

JM: Oh yeah. Well I don't think there's anything wrong with somebody going to a conservatory to study music and to study jazz. But I've never yet met a program, I mean just consider what they produce. They produce people that know about Dizzy Gillespie and Charlie Parker and pros and everything like that. And I guess some courses they treat history. But forget it. And then they all play the latest thing — oh about the definition of jazz. It's got to have freedom, yeah. And I like the idea of modern jazz and what they produce but I don't actually like the music you know. It's a very curious thing. As I said before, if somebody just asked me do I like jazz, I say no, because I know what they're thinking and I don't like it. And let's put it this way: jazz is so compartmentalized. There are so many aspects. And America's got this bad history of antagonism between the styles of jazz. You know in Norway I went to a party celebrating somebody's thirtieth anniversary in the business and all the jazz musicians were there: the modern, the beboppers, they were all there and they gave somebody an award and they all had a drink and had a meal. You know, and that felt very un-American. I'm sorry to say it, especially in New York they just dice and slice each other you know. But maybe because work is so scarce.

MR: Yeah. Did you ever have any issues with traveling in an integrated group when you were with Louis?

JM: No.

MR: We'll take a short pause here. I think this is a fellow you might know actually.

JM: Who's that.

MR: Hi come on in.

VG: Oh Joe Muranyi, don't believe anything he says.

MR: I'm trying not to.

JM: Hey did you get my email?

VG: Is this on the film?

MR: This is on the film now.

VG: Oh Jesus I'm sorry.

MR: That's all right. We're just wrapping up. You guys can just — we're a little cramped here.

TH: We were supposed to have a suite and this is what we have.

JM: Great to see you, Vinnie, I think you deserve to be interviewed man.

VG: Well I don't know about that.

JM: Yeah, go on.

MR: I'm trying to remember what we were talking about.

JM: About jazz, about liking jazz or not liking jazz. Well there was some factor you were going to.

MR: The jazz education we were talking about — oh I know, I was just wondering about when you traveled with Louis, that the group was integrated, if it ever became an issue traveling anywhere.

JM: You mean the fact that he was black or that it was a mixed band?

MR: Yes, it was a mixed band.

JM: No. By the time I was there, I heard him refer, he'd meet some of his old buddies would come up and there was one he was talking about, I had $2,000 in my pocket, he said, and I had no place to sleep or eat or anything. So that came up, but art, you know, art actually.

MR: Well it's been really fascinating.

JM: Okay.

MR: I enjoyed talking to you and I wish you the best of luck.

JM: I need a miracle.

MR: You're going back overseas soon? You have something scheduled?

JM: Oh I think in June I've got something. There's an annual Louis Armstrong festival, this is the third annual.

MR: I see.

JM: And I'm sort of the jovial emcee in Hungarian.

MR: Okay. Well thank you.

JM: Okay Rowe, Monk Rowe, it's nice talking with you.

MR: My pleasure.

JM: I hope you got enough.

MR: I did.